

Revision of tenses (uses)

Present and Past

I. The present

1. Present simple and Present Continuous

Present simple	Present continuous
- Repeated action Eg. I use my computer every day. - General truth/fact Eg. Computers are useful. I have a computer.	- Temporary actions fulfilled at the moment of speaking. Eg. A: What are you doing? B: I am programming. - Temporary actions fulfilled NOT NECESSARILY at the moment of speaking. Eg. He is developing a new app. this week.

2. Present perfect simple and Present Perfect Continuous

The use of these two tenses differs from whether we are describing a **finished action** or an **unfinished action**.

A. Present perfect simple vs present perfect continuous for **FINISHED ACTIONS**

Present perfect simple	Present perfect continuous
Recently stopped I've just finished reading <i>L'Opium et le Baton</i> by Mouloud Mammeri.	recently stopped It has been raining. (the ground is still wet) I have been reading <i>L'Opium et le Baton</i>. (focused on the activity as recently stopped)
Finished actions indefinite time I've read <i>L'Opium et le Baton</i> by Mouloud Mammeri. (focused on the completed result of the action considered as an achievement)	

B. Present perfect simple vs present perfect continuous for **UNFINISHED ACTIONS**

Present perfect simple	Present perfect continuous
Describes duration or repetition until now	Describes duration or repetition until now
Sometimes chosen to emphasize long-term duration Eg. I have taught English for about 18 years.	Sometimes chosen to emphasize short-term duration I have been teaching at this school for less than one year.

Sometimes chosen to emphasize occasional repetition (until now). A: How many times have you used the library? B: I've rarely used it.	Sometimes chosen to emphasize frequent repetition (until now). A: How many times have you used the library? B: I've been using the library every day since I came to this school.
Used with for, since, how long	Used with for, since, how long
Used after the first, the second (etc) time...	

II. The past

1. Past simple and present perfect simple

Past simple	Present perfect simple
Describes finished actions finished period of time ie it should be used with time conjunctions or any other indication referring to the exact time when the action happened. I read <i>L' Opium et le Baton</i> by Mouloud Mammeri last year. Mouloud Mammeri wrote many novels. (though there is no time conjunction, the fact that Mammeri is dead shows that the time of the action is finished.	Finished actions indefinite time I have read <i>L' Opium et le Baton</i>. (without time conjunction, focused on the completed result of the action considered as an achievement)

2. Past perfect simple

In a sequence of events which happened in the past, we use the past perfect simple to show that one action occurred before another one in the past.

I knew (that) I had seen her somewhere before.

It had stopped raining so they didn't bother to put the car away.

Note1: If the events happened are simultaneous, we use the past simple to describe both actions.

Note 2: If the sequence of events is obvious, ie it is clear from context which action happened first and which one happened second, we use the past simple to describe both actions.

3. Past continuous vs Past perfect Continuous

These two tenses describe the progress of an action in the past which is always measured in relation to a specified moment in the past (this moment can be an exact time as it can be another action which indeed happened at an exact time in the past).

Past continuous	Past perfect continuous
Describes something which began before a particular point in the past and continues after it. I was still working at 6:00.	Describes something which began before a particular point in the past and continues after it. I had been still working at 6:00.

Describes something which was in progress when something else happened to interrupt it(Interrupted past) I was working when a power cut occurred.	Describes progress or repetition, which stopped before or at a particular point in the past, (but not interrupted). I was working when you called.
Describes an action which extended over an extended period of time. I was working from 8:00 to 12:00.	Describes an action that has recently stopped before a particular point in the past. You had been using my computer; the battery was hot.

Note

When tenses describe the same use, they can be used alternately, i.e. we can use both tenses to describe the action.